

Digital Shards in Issue Space of South Asian Immigration: An Algorithmic Autoethnography
of Recommended Feed and Auto-Netnographic study of Remediation through Comments

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Chapter 1

Introduction

What once began as a digital network designed to enable cultures to connect people beyond geographical boundaries through social media platforms is no longer functioning in the same way. Instead of being a platform where public discussions occur in unison, modern day social media have fragmented public issues into many different narratives rather than allowing for the presentation of those issues in their entirety. Today, social media platforms do not present public issues as unified or stable debates (Ma and Zhang 2022). On platforms such as Instagram, political and cultural issues appear through posts, reels, captions, hashtags, memes, and algorithmically ranked feeds. These fragments are not encountered in a neutral sequence. They are selected, organized, and circulated through platform systems that prioritize signals like visibility, engagement, continued user attention etc (Bareither and Wirth 2025). As a result, users often encounter only partial versions of larger issues, detached from their broader historical, political, and social contexts. This thesis examines this condition through the concept of sharding. In its technical sense, a shard refers to a fragment of a larger whole. In the context of digital culture, however, sharding can be understood as a process through which a public issue is broken into multiple partial, competing, and unevenly visible representations that tend to follow a particular template (Merrin and Hoskins 2024).

A user scrolling through Instagram does not necessarily encounter an issue such as immigration as a coherent policy debate or a shared public problem. Instead, this issue may appear through separate controversies like crime, labour, welfare, national identity, religion, racism or cultural integration in the form of shards (Hoskins and Merrin 2025). Once a user has encountered a shard and interacted with it through the affordances of Instagram like commenting, sharing, liking and saving the posts, it signals the algorithm of Instagram to recommend more shards related to immigration. This tends to make the user part of the particular issue space (Rogers 2019).

Each post is a fragment of a controversy in the issue space of immigration. No single post provides the complete structure through which the controversy can be understood within the issue space. This fragmentation becomes significant because social media platforms do not merely transmit information. They also shape how information appears, how it is connected to other content, and how users are invited to respond in the issue space. But what happens when the issue space is narrowed down to one particular group or diaspora?

Take the example of Vickrum Digwa, a British Indian Sikh, who was arrested for the murder of Henry Novak, a Britisher with Polish roots in 2025. The first post that the researcher encountered about this controversy is the sentencing of Digwa for the murder of Novak in 2026. Upon further scrolling, the researcher was able to see multiple shards of the same controversy. Most of these were propagating different aspects of the same controversy like banning of the kirpan or the ceremonial knife carried around by Sikhs, protestors attacking Digwa's home, the Reform Party trying to take advantage of the incident for political gain and some shards even claiming that Digwa is a Muslim. Each user in this issue space will have encountered a different shard of the same controversy. Hence, the controversy has been splintered into shards and the affordance of commenting on these shards have enabled the remediation of the event from a murder to a call for an all-out attack on all British Sikhs (Paternoster and Nilsson-Julien 2026) (Wright 2026).

When a user encounters an issue like immigration through fragments of multiple controversies in the particular context of a group like the South Asian Diaspora, interpretations about the group is made. These shards are framed on the basis of different controversies based on fear, sympathy, humour, anger, moral outrage, or national belonging (Hoskins and Merrin 2025). These fragments are made meaningful through prior knowledge, political orientation, cultural background, affective response, and the platform context which differs for each user. These shards are then remediated through the affordances of the platform like images, captions, comments etc. In this process, an idea is formed about the diaspora in the issue space of immigration that is represented through multiple shards of controversies which is reorganized into platform-specific forms that are designed to be quickly consumed, emotionally processed, and circulated further.

However, because different users have differed understanding of these fragments and the fact that different users encounter these shards in the issue space based on their own personalized algorithms, the same issue will not be collectively understood. What appears to one user as a humanitarian crisis may appear to another as a security threat, an economic burden, a cultural conflict, or a political conspiracy based on the order of the posts that they see. The issue space is therefore not only fragmented at the level of content, but also at the level of interpretation. The representation of these fragmented controversies at multiple levels tends to influence the opinion of the users of a particular issue space of immigration of South Asian Diaspora.

Different studies have been conducted on the presence of the Asian Diaspora in online social media platforms. Nguyễn et. al. studied disinformation in Asian diasporic communities to examine the dominance of Anglocentrism and better understand the role of historical, transnational, multilingual and intergenerational networks in the information infrastructure of media platforms like Instagram, Facebook and Twitter (Nguyễn et al. 2022). Ansar and Maitra studied the Digital Diaspora activism of the Rohingya community by analysing 34,905 posts in Facebook to understand how it serves as place to keep their memory of home alive, as a gateway to seek global attention and to promote an emerging narrative of Muslim solidarity to help manifest their political resistance (Anas Ansar and Maitra 2024). Sharman et. al. studied about misinformation related to the COVID-19 pandemic amongst the South Asian Diaspora that circulated through WhatsApp. They did this by using a method called COVID-19–Associated misinfoRmation On Messaging apps (CAROM) to identify the messages that contained misinformation (Sharma et al. 2023).

This thesis argues that Instagram contributes to the sharding of the immigration issue space of the South Asian Diaspora by circulating fragmented representations of controversies in the personalized algorithmic feed of users. Rather than treating social media posts as isolated pieces of content, the thesis examines how they function as shards of a specific issue space. The central concern is not whether individual posts are true or false, but how the post and the comments attached to them participate in the production and remediation of partial and affective understanding of a specific diaspora like the South Asians in a particular issue space like immigration.

Through this approach, the thesis seeks to understand how platform algorithm, fragmentation of controversies, and the interpretation of the response of users through affordance of commenting contribute to sharding and the remediation of controversies in the specific issue space. This will be guided by the research question: How do algorithmic sharding and remediation through comments generate meaning which influence how consensus and dissent is voiced about the South Asian Diaspora within the online issue space of immigration?

To answer this research question, an autoethnographic approach will be taken to collect and analyse data from Instagram to understand the opinion that is generated about the South Asian Diaspora. Based on the data that is collected autoethnographically, a map of the issue space can be generated using co-tag analysis based on the hashtags of the posts. This

map will help identify the specific controversy clusters of posts that are present in this issue space. The shards in the controversy clusters would be studied to understanding the behaviour of sharding in the issue space through pixplot visualization, stack video and scene-by-scene timeline analysis. Finally, the remediation of the posts would be studied auto-netnographically through the comments section of the posts to understand what do the users in this issue space think about the South Asian Diaspora from the perspective of consent/dissent.

Chapter 2

Theoretical Framework

2.1 Issue Mapping and Social Media

The South Asian Diaspora also known as the Desi Diaspora (Prashad 2012) has a significant presence in Europe. Coming from India, Pakistan, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka, this diaspora started immigrating to Europe during the colonial era. In the present day, this migration has made Europe a haven for skilled professionals and students from South Asia (Sahoo 2025) (Ohnsorge and Xie 2025). Along with immigration, the diaspora brings along with them their culture and ideologies, which they try to inculcate in their communities.

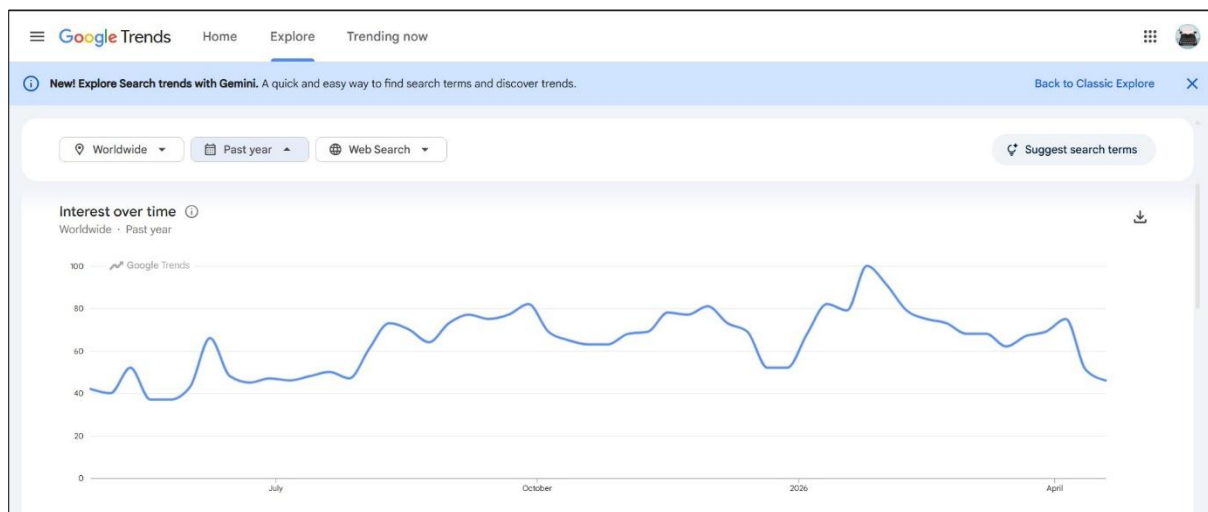


Figure 2.1 Google Trends search result for the term Immigration

There has been a recent uptake in problems faced by South Asians especially when it comes to topics like immigration and racism. Figure 1 shows the search result in Google Trends for the word immigration, indicating the extent to which the term has been searched in the past year. The rise of the far right in Europe has led to many countries like UK to organize anti-immigration protests and attacks against South Asians and other immigrants (Wike et al. 2026). This has resulted in an increase in discussion of controversies related to South Asians which has made social media platforms to act like an amplifier (Burgess, Bruns, and Osman 2019, 1) of issues and has created an issue network of influence based on anxiety amongst the users and the public.

Issue network as a term was first coined by American political scientist Hugo Heclo to critique a web/network of policy pressure groups active in politics. Defined as a formation of

loose alliances among issue-activists, issue-experts and issue-watchers, they defined issues by sharing information about them (Marres and Rogers 2005, 927). According to Marres and Rogers, the establishment of such issue networks tend to introduce opacity, complexity and ready-made issue definitions into the political process leading to the undermining of public involvement in politics (Marres and Rogers 2005, 925) which leads the users to be influenced by the topics discussed in the issue network. The volatile nature of social media and search engines makes platforms and infrastructures to increasingly promote the dynamic valorization of content (Marres 2015, 671). At the same time, these profit-making ventures are relentlessly seeking to keep the users engaged by manipulating their fear of missing out (Milmo 2021). This dynamic nature of topics being formatted as happening issues makes it difficult to differentiate between past, stable and active topics of interest (Marres 2015, 671).

This shift in the process of formation of issue network from the real to the digital world through social media made it a new place to practice lobbyism for a select number of users (Marres and Rogers 2005, 2). These select number of users through the affordances offered by social media platforms, can create a narrative about the topic of immigration and target a specific population as the root cause of their problems in their countries. In short, in the context of social media, an issue network based on immigration can be defined as “a heterogenous set of entities (actors, documents, slogans, imagery) that have configured into a hyperlink network around a common problematic, summed up in a key word.” (Marres and Rogers 2005, 927) In the context of this research, the key word is immigration, specifically of the South Asian Diaspora and the controversies that are part of its issue network.

As a visual tool, networks give the researcher an opportunity to explore the relationship between the actors and the controversies in the issue space. But the main disadvantage of this tool is that it tends to flatten the landscape and hides crucial features like how political power is disguised and compressed into technical affordances of the platform like algorithm which favour the platform more than the users (Venturini and Munk 2021). Therefore, a group of users are trying to manipulate the algorithm by introducing opacity into a complex issue like immigration, which they succeed when there is increased engagement from the side of the users which prompts the platform to start pushing more such posts.

2.2 Navigating the Issue Network through Controversies

To understand the issue network of the South Asian Diaspora and the controversies that they are part of it is necessary to understand how to navigate this network and its

components in social media. This can be accomplished by mapping the issue network. The process of issue mapping, according to Noortje Marres, involves “accepting the inherent ambiguity of the object or topic in the context of the substantive and evolving nature of media technology and not reducing it to a media technological process” (Marres 2015). Immigration as a topic has multiple perspectives which are being shared through social media. It cannot be reduced to only a process in the context of a multifaceted algorithm-based process like social media. The process also has a tendency for its consequences to spread into the real world also.

At the same time, Bruno Latour connects issue mapping with Actor Network Theory which discusses how humans and non-humans (objects, ideas, processes) are of equal importance when explaining any phenomena by defining them as actors or actants in a network. Latour gives three defining characteristics relevant to the practice of issue mapping: Latour sees social as a structure and not a movement, the role of the social researcher is redefined as tracing associations created by the actions of the actors involved in the issue space and pays close attention to the widening inclusion of non-human actors and its relation with its corresponding controversies. All three steps are considered equally relevant in navigating an issue space. (Rogers, Sánchez-Querubín, and Aleksandra Kil 2015). Hence, to map the terrain of an issue network of a topic like immigration, the social media terrain through which information flows must be analysed, where the researcher must trace the actions of the actors or in this case the posts discussing the controversies involved and must also take into consideration the non-human actors i.e. the affordances of the platform.

Controversy according to Burgess et. al. who wrote a paper on the Australia Day Controversy is defined as topics of shared concern marked by uncertainty or contestation (Burgess, Bruns, and Osman 2019). The controversy is propagated through amplifier platforms which are designed specifically to translate and publicly disseminate information to a general audience which can be anything from news sites to sites for scholarly discussion and even social media. Social media hold significant promise for controversy analysis for two main reasons: first, they signal a further mainstreaming and wider uptake of digital media technologies in and across social media to be used as a source of information for professional and public life, “thereby extending their empirical relevance as a setting and a breeding ground for societal controversies”. Second, “they make available more richly structured data than Web data as such” (Gerlitz & Lury 2014, Marres and Moats 2015, 4). Taken together, the

controversies that make up an issue space can give significant data about the behaviour of the issue network which can influence the users.

Controversy mapping in social media also fulfils the objective of making visible the validity of expert knowledge which is based on a series of claims which support or oppose each other. These series of claims are made by multiple accounts which act as actors in the issue space. They compose, morph or change the status at times depending on where the controversy stands in real time. Hence the mapping of controversy must be done through a pragmatic approach where the focus must be on finding ways to study how tensions animate in a collective network (based on immigration) of actors and not separating the controversial and non-controversial. It indicates that controversies are an integral component of any issue network and navigating these different controversies gives a better understanding of how an issue like immigration is being discussed, shared and understood from the perspective of an individual user in social media (Venturini and Munk 2021).

2.3 Analysing Controversies in Issue Network

A wide variety of controversies can be found in an issue network based on immigration in the form of posts that are posted by different users. So, to understand the network, digital methods can be employed. The analysis of controversies as a digital method according to Noortje Marres involves “the use of computational techniques to detect, analyze, and visualize public contestation over topical affairs” (Marres 2015, 657). Therefore, controversies unfolding in a social media setting, is a chance to analyse both the substantive issues in the form of controversy as well as the formative role it plays enabled by the mediating role technologies play in the enactment of these controversies (Marres and Moats 2015, 1).

Marres discusses three approaches to analysing controversy in an issue space: Demarcationist, Discursive and Empiricist. Demarcationist approach of controversy analysis via computational methods aim to delineate the legitimate from the illegitimate knowledge sources and disputes. The Discursive approach focuses on sociological methods where the objective is not to decide the status of a topic, but to map the position of the controversy in the issue network. In contrast to these approaches, Empiricists focus on how the controversy is heterogeneously composed in ways that cannot be predetermined by the researcher (Marres 2015, 660-663).

This thesis will focus on the discursive and empirical approach, as it is trying to understand how immigration of the South Asian Diaspora is being discussed in social media through the different controversies that a user encounters in their own personalized and algorithm influenced issue space of immigration. By deploying digital methods of analysis, this method would help demonstrate the entangling of epistemic and political dynamics, in a dynamically evolving medium like social media (Marres 2015, 663).

2.4 Role of Bias in the Issue Network

When discussing the issue network which is composed of controversies posted by users, the issue of bias comes into the fore. When the issue space of immigration that is propagating different controversies is studied, it is important to understand how digital bias through algorithm tends to influence the users.

Marres points out that digital bias tends to undermine the analysis of issues and its controversies. Digital methods of controversy analysis are potentially biased because “the instruments they deploy to describe controversy—search engines and social media platforms—exert a notable influence on the enactment of controversy online, which places serious limits on the generalizability of the insights of digital controversy analysis” (Marres 2015, 657). Digital bias threatens to undermine controversy analysis because the researcher cannot be sure that “he/she is analysing the controversies themselves, rather than the digital settings that make these controversies analysable” (Marres 2015, 657). By studying the issue space and the network of controversies present in it, the digital setting and the controversies are separated, making it easy to understand the bias for/against the controversy through the affordances like post, hashtag, commenting etc.

Marres discusses about two very different ways to treat the methodological problem of digital bias in online controversy analysis. The precautionary approach treats digital media technologies as a source of noise that must be neutralized, while the affirmative approach treats digital devices as an empirical resource for controversy analysis. This thesis follows the affirmative approach discussed above by taking into consideration a key feature of controversy analysis as a digital method (Marres 2015, 664-665). According to Marres and Moats, such an analysis of controversies enables a symmetrical approach to the study of media technological dynamics and issue dynamics. This symmetry principles pertains not to knowledge and politics but to content and media (Marres and Moats 2015, 12).

By analysing controversies from this perspective, it could help explain how “robust controversies” are detected in terms of topical dynamics (how viral the topic is) while the “failed controversies” can be explained through the lens of media technological dynamics (how the algorithm favours the topic which can be used on an old post). The dynamics here refers to the dynamic valorization of robust and failed controversies where search engines and platform algorithms privilege “fresh” information, and social media seek to keep their users engaged by continuously keeping them in the loop of “what is happening”. This allows an opportunity to closely pay attention to the ways in which a digital platform and users through bias manipulates public issues, and to how controversies spread beyond the issue space as an object of public attention.

2.5 Effect of Time and Risk in an Issue Network

But it is interesting to note that the posts which discuss the controversies in the issue network may not always be fresh or latest information. As mentioned in the Introduction, a post can be created in the issue space with an event that has occurred even before the date on which the post was posted. This ambiguity of the source and more specifically the ‘timing’ of the information is explained through the roles of the Intermediary and the Mediator in the social media landscape. An intermediary is a user who transports meaning or force without transformation. Here the user posts, shares and comments the post without any critical reflection. A mediator on the other hand, transform, translate, distort, and modify the meaning or the elements in a post and can even create a new one based on old posts that were posted at an earlier period (Rogers, Sánchez-Querubín, and Aleksandra Kil 2015, 16-17). Here, a user with the intention of misleading other users, creates and shares post at differing dates with a specific agenda like immigration in mind as the main objective to make more users ‘believe’ in the issue network.

Furthermore, the information that they share might be a reiteration or an update of previously publicized controversies which they are trying to convert into a robust controversy to keep the issue network active. Therefore, it is important for the researcher to understand that it is not only the affordances of the social media platform that allow the propagation of controversies in the issue network. Users or actors in the form of intermediaries and mediators also work in tandem by manipulating the timing of the posts in the issue network to sustain its ideas.

In order to understand this magmatic effect controversy has on its users in the network of the issue space of immigration, the concept of risk mentioned in Ulrich Beck's work *World Risk Society* can be used. According to Beck, risk is defined as "the thematization of future threats or catastrophes which depends entirely on decisions, which bring error, ignorance, the promise of control and possible self-destruction". In other words, risk exist as the outcome of both our impossibility to fully know the consequences that our present actions will have in the future and the contradictory desire to try to predict and control these unknowns. The risk here is presented through multiple contradictory versions of the issue through controversies which presents a fictionalized or supposed version of the future (Rogers, Sánchez-Querubín, and Aleksandra Kil 2015, 19).

This version is dramatized by denying and accepting by the actors in the issue network who can decides what aspects of the controversies in the issue network is and not a risk through the affordances of the platform. This makes an issue like immigration a risk as it is less calculable, which makes it more risky or uncertain where it gains symbolic, political and affective force influenced by uncertainty which sustains the issue network and its controversies. Hence, a risk management of an issue space like immigration of South Asian diaspora is a difficult task as they are governed through struggles over definition, staging, timing, distribution and the responses it gets from the users and the platform (Rogers, Sánchez-Querubín, and Aleksandra Kil 2015, 21).

2.6 Sharding of Controversies in the Issue Space

The previous section has given an insight into how failed controversies can be converted to robust controversies and that they never die down. This makes them a risk as they spread without any limitations because of the users and the algorithm of the platform. Media, specifically social media is considered as an epistemological engine which manufactures meaning which influences consent and dissent amongst the users (Hoskins and Merrin 2025, 3). Earlier this role was taken up by the broadcast media, where information was in a shared, mass consensual mainstream bubble. The power for the creation of information was always in the hands of the people who had the resources and permissions to do them. According to Hoskins and Merrin, licenses, qualifications, skills, a key position in the communication hierarchy and access to expensive and complex equipment limited the ability to produce and share the real that was generated by one common entity (Hoskins and Merrin 2025, 27). But this changed with the introduction of the smartphone, when Apple

launched its first iPhone in 2007 (Farber 2007). The culture of creation shifted from the hands of professional creators to amateurs who had access to all the different tools that they needed in one device. Along with this, the producers of the real also lost their ability and power to gatekeep a shared common version of reality (Hoskins and Merrin 2025, 27).

This has resulted in the repetition of ideas and sameness becoming the core strategy promoted on the Internet itself. The algorithm based social media system functions on a fine line of “tension between the individual and collective dimensions of sameness” (Tosca 2023, 113). This model of operation of social media is based on the “sameness maximising system of meaning and consumption” (Tosca 2023, 2). This repetition of posts in social media can result in giving an idea attention and appropriation of the idea which gives pleasure to the users. This when connected to a social dimension like fear or risk creates a tension between engagement and boredom and may result in providing transcendence to a completely new belief system and reality for the users (Tosca 2023). This consumption of the visually same near duplicates or “exact-duplicates, or any manipulated versions that often appear on social media, including extreme or adversarial manipulations (e.g. memes, sever cropping, splicing etc.)” (Matatov, Naaman, and Amir 2022) around a topic like immigration can result in creation of a sense of sameness amongst the users. This process according to Susanna Tosca allows them to group objects into recognisable categories that users can use as cognitive frames and guides for their consumption (Tosca 2023, 11).

At this juncture of analysing controversies through an issue space in social media, the concepts of sharding emerges as relevant. Sharding as a concept was first used to explain the phenomenon of sharded war, which was first observed during the Russia Ukraine War that escalated in 2021. The concept was derived from online, multi-player video games like World of Warcraft, where ‘sharding’ is a game design tool that helped to prevent gamer overcrowding to improve server performance. When the game reaches a specific number of users, the game creates a new ‘shard’—a new copy of that area, to allow users to enjoy it without experiencing any lag or loss of performance. Hence, gamers can ‘live’ the same world, the same game processes, without realising they exist in separate worlds with no possibility of interaction. Similar to the new copy of area created in games, shards in the context of social media are produced when a user takes videos, photos, memes from other posts and produces a new post in a different context. This is done through immediation, (where photographs, videos and snippets of content are immediately taken, posted and receives instantaneous reactions) and remediation (where the immediated material is remixed

and reinterpreted across different platforms) which creates multiple shards of the same idea. (Merrin and Hoskins 2024, 117). A shard therefore has the ability to completely change the real story behind the video/photo. But what are the chances that the same videos can be used to create shards especially in a medium like social media where duplication, repetition and a sense of sameness of “ideas” are promoted?

According to Merrin and Hoskins, “the explosion of the mass-consensual bubble; the extinction cascade of the broadcast ecology of the real; the fractalisation of information; the orbitalised launching of individual medianauts; the blooming of personally created and connected foam cities: they all point to the splintering of experience, knowledge and reality.” (Hoskins and Merrin 2025, 31). According to media theorists, news amplification, dramatisation, shock and trauma, especially on television, have always been followed by containment (Hoskins and Merrin 2025, 9). But the sharding that we are seeing in a social media ecosystem today, is based on a personalised click-bait attention economy which has very few restraints making it difficult to contain. Individuals in their personal filter bubbles source their own dopamine, which they are constantly exposed to when they become part of an echo chamber in an issue space. They don’t need to depend on mainstream media for information today. The splintered individual realities are achieved through sharding whereby users are exposed to so much information in the form of perspectives based on a key event like immigration that the algorithmic feed and personalized ability to search, splinters the reality about the key event for each user. Just as in massively multi-player online video games, reality is digitally sharded and gamified through the affordances offered by the social media platform, which users believe they have full control. In reality, the data that the users share for these affordances makes the platform more powerful to an extent that they can control which issue space that the user are inhabiting. Once they enter the issue space, it tends to become their default preference, and the platform promotes the posts with the same idea which have the ability to change the perspective about the issue for the users.

As mentioned in the previous paragraphs, social media today has become a bubble machine where the users have a perceived power to choose which bubble they wish to inhabit. The echoing nature of these bubbles is caused due to the overproduction of content based on a variety of controversies in the issue space leading to an exponential hyper production of truths which creates realities that each user specifically wants to believe in. This overproduction at a massive scale is due to the enabling nature of social media platforms that gives the users freedom to share, produce and see anything and even the worst of

humanity, also called toxic sludge which does not find a place in mainstream media. Every action in the form of creating, commenting, liking or sharing a shard is leading to the creation of a hyporeality – the lowest degree of reality necessary to project, claim or believe anything (Hoskins and Merrin 2025, 30).

The broadcast media according to Jean Baudrillard was based on the notion of Hyperreality. According to Baudrillard, hyperreality was achieved by “huge organisations who gathered and deployed vast stocks of *media materiel* or shards to create and perfect the real” which is completely different from reality (Hoskins and Merrin 2025, 28). Now the influence of broadcast media has reduced significantly and the power over the “real” or the belief that users are seeing the true reality is now in the hands of amateur individuals. Here personally produced content is inflated by individuals to such an extent that they become a personalized simulated reality and deflates the shared real promoted by a powerful broadcast media. The resulting hyporeality contributes to the deterioration of the real as the authority of the real is now in the hands of multiple individuals. These individuals are not interested in expert verification, shared institutional power and ability to control the repetition of post. They are only interested in personally producing and circulating a “real” that they believe in. The real hence is now very easy to produce and dangerously believable that it can replace reality itself for some.

When different groups of individuals in an echo chamber start producing the real in their issue space according to their ideologies, the resulting hyporeality starts to behave like a ‘foam city’ a term coined by Peter Sloterdijk. The echo chamber is composed of individual, monadic bubbles which are not atomized or separated. Rather they are always in motion, continually connecting and reforming like foam. The millions of bubbles eventually make foam cities which are “not simply an agglomeration of neighbouring (partition-sharing) inert and massive bodies, but rather multiplicities of loosely touching cells of life-worlds” (Sloterdijk, 2016, 565).

According to Merrin, “anyone with a smartphone and internet connection can become an empowered producer of content, messages and information.” (Hoskins and Merrin 2025, 27). The epistemological engine has now become highly individualized bubbles in a foam city where anyone who has access to a phone can create content or their version of the real based on any incident that they encounter along with their “experience, knowledge, concepts of truth, and horizons of thought.” (Hoskins and Merrin 2025, 3) These ideas when posted on

a medium like social media controlled by an algorithm and operated through its affordances, tends to make them part of a filter bubble in an echo chamber (Rhodes 2021).

This has resulted in each of the users to wage their own wars where an explosion of biased content is “competing to lie, disseminate, to beat other narratives and to win with filters, lies and memes” (Hoskins and Merrin 2025, 33). The digital reality of society is constantly in a state of war which is not against a common enemy, rather a multitude of enemies present in the digital world which is highly personalized and does not behave collectively.

2.7 Remediation of Shards and Affect on Users

We have now understood that controversies in an issue space are shards or different videos made using the same template to propagate a particular idea and show the South Asian Diaspora through a specific and problematic lens. In some instances, some members of the diaspora do commit certain acts that tend to make the idea propagated about them to be true. But the sharded nature of social media has the capability to make the users believe that the whole diaspora is dangerous and a threat to the society as a whole. So how is this idea presented through shards of controversies in the issue space of users evolving? This evolution of the idea through sharding is made possible through immediation and hypermediation which when combined results in remediation (Bolter and Grusin 2000).

Remediation as a concept has been used to understand how new media formats replicate and build on more traditional media formats, explicating the materiality of media and can also show how the reproduction and alternations of media occur in circulation from context to context (Toivanen, Nelimarkka, and Valaskivi 2021). The same definition can be applied to the posts created in social media, but instead of materiality, the main focus is on how the idea of a post is reproduced and altered to create a completely new context or understanding for the same controversy. The present culture of hyporeality is in a race to erase traces of the real by multiplying them. Unlike how new media was seen by the users as refashioned and improved versions of old media, here the affordances of new media have allowed the refashioning of media, but not to create improved version, but rather to remediate the meaning of the controversy into a completely new perspective (Bolter and Grusin 2000, 15).

In these situations, the logic of immediacy or immediation is the first step before remediation. According to Bolter and Grusin, “the logic of immediacy dictates that the

medium itself should disappear and leave us in the presence of the thing represented which leads one to either erase or render automatic the act of representation” (Bolter and Grusin 2000, 33). When the user sees a version of an event that has happened, it transfers the user to the event itself. It makes the user believe that he/she is involved in the event. The affordances of the social media platform here gives the user the ability to either erase their act of representation by choosing not to react or automatically shares, comments or likes the content as it appeals to the user. But a significant observation is that the user tends to fully believe the feed they receive. Instead of investigating the source of the event or knowing if such a thing has really happened, they believe the text, visuals and body of the post, as it appeals to their belief systems which as mentioned above is being formed in a highly unregulated echo chamber.

At this point in the discussion, the second step in the process of remediation of shards sets into motion through the logic of hypermediation. According to William J Mitchell, “hypermediation, privileges fragmentation, indeterminacy, and heterogeneity and emphasizes process or performance rather than the finished art object which leads to the acknowledgement of multiple acts of representation and makes them even more visible” (Bolter and Grusin 2000, 31). This is where certain users take the content or idea of the post with a deliberate intention to mislead or disinform audiences because the “designers of hypermediated forms ask users to take pleasure in the act of mediation, and even our popular culture does take pleasure” (Bolter and Grusin 2000, 14) While immediacy is presenting a unified visual space which has a common opinion about a controversy in the issue space, hypermediation makes it into a heterogeneous space where it is conceived not as a “window” to the issue space, but rather as “windowed” itself with different windows that open on to other representations of the controversy (Bolter and Grusin 2000, 34).

This is when remediation becomes fully active as immediacy and hypermediacy’s relationship results in remediation of the content of the controversy. New Media in the form of social media is remediating a controversy in the issue space by refashioning or repositioning the idea with ambiguous motives to create homage or rivalry by exploiting what Harold Bloom calls “the anxiety of influence” amongst the users where they tend to misread the posts in their struggle to find originality and meaning (Tosca 2023, 29). This progresses to a new phase when the remediated media is shared amongst different social media platforms. According to Marres and Hoskins, these platforms are not disconnected entities and are “localised experiences fed through apps which are remediated through other, broader apps

and platforms, usually in more explicable forms for global audiences” (Merrin and Hoskins 2024, 116). This shows that both the platforms and users also play an equal role here.

Amongst the processes involved in the creation of shards, remediation can be considered more dangerous as it contributes to misinformation as the content is acting as a form of countermedia to the traditional broadcast media. Remediation through social media is occurring through constant commentary, reproduction and replacement by the users to expand their issue space and keep it more relevant (Bolter and Grusin, 1998, 55). To keep the flow of remediated information, the gatekeeping of the content and its format has decreased drastically (Toivanen, Nelimarkka, and Valaskivi 2021, 2128). This combined with unintentionally sharing of a mix of false information or misinformation and facts results in content confusion making it difficult to separate the new and repeated controversies in the issue space (Hermans, Waeterloos, and Opgenhaffen 2025). This remediated information makes an individual user to make their social media feed as the preferred form of countermedia. Instead of reframing salient aspects of mainstream media content, it is combined with toxic sludge to create remediated shards which fit the user’s perceived reality creating a highly individualized countermedia. This remediation of both fact and information produced through amateur content is consciously chosen by users from a political perspective based on authenticity and affective reactions to establish certain ideas about a topic like immigration through controversies in the issue space (Toivanen, Nelimarkka, and Valaskivi 2021, 2131).

Social Media platforms behave like a permissive potentate, where platforms govern the economic transactions in the app not by expanding their control over their users but rather through relinquishing important dimensions of control and delegating them to the other parties in the exchange i.e. the users (Vallas and Schor 2020). They believe that they have full control of the filter bubble and echo chamber when they are using these platforms. But in actuality, these platforms are allowing users to believe in a simulation of control. Along with this, the role of affect becomes significant here. With the belief that they have full control, users when seeing posts that appeal to them feel a “matter of impact, force and contact, that builds up, modulates and oscillates in daily encounters in a heterogeneous” (Paasonen 2014, 702) hyporeality that they inhabit. This affect is what pushes users to circulate algorithmically determined products which again returns “desired” content back to the user. This creates an affective feedback loop which according to Papacharissi makes the users to attain affective attunement leading to computational propaganda and the dynamic

reproduction of political subjectivity of the controversies that they see in the filter bubbles of their echo chambers in the issue space (Boler and Davis 2018). This algorithmic imaginary of how the algorithm functions “have the power to enact material realities by shaping social life to various degrees” results in what Tania Bucher calls a collaborative identity construction (Bucher 2016). This identity is enhanced amongst the users of the issue space pushing a particular agenda through the affordances of the platform like tagging, commenting and liking.

This is the reason why Merrin and Hoskins says that, “the most visible wars in history are the least collectively shared and understood” (Merrin and Hoskins 2024, 118) To better understand this war that is occurring through the remediation of shards that is happening in social media, a post from the dataset used in the research is taken here. The first post that the researcher encountered was from a page called the_spotlight3485 which was a video with a caption titled “In England, Indian customers, starting vandalizing kebab shops after seeing beef on the menu” posted on 11th February 2026. The same video was again seen by the researcher in his feed but from a different page titled mr_abaha posted on 17th February 2026 which propagated the same idea as the previous post.

The same video was used by two users to tell the same idea that Hindu Indians were beat up by restaurant owners for seeing beef in the menu. But upon further research, it was found that the video was based on an incident that happened in January 2025 involving British Pakistanis and not Indian Hindus (Aditi 2025). This repetition of the same video by two different users easily created two shards that produced a completely different story or real that had no connection with reality. The event that occurred in 2025 was immediated to create a post. The same event was hypermediated two create two more posts which together resulted in remediation and producing three shards individually. These three shards together completely remediated the facts and now the remediated idea that Indians and Pakistanis who are a major part of the South Asian Diaspora are troublemakers is now circulating in the issue space. The visible war in the issue space of immigration is therefore fragmented and is shared and viewed individually which makes it the least understood.

Similarly, videos with the same template or structure but with different subjects can be also considered as shards as the sharding is occurring through the remediation of different controversies being discussed in the issue space. Hence, in the context of the controversies in the issue space of immigration of South Asian Diaspora, it is the controversies that are being

sharded through different videos by following the same template and idea that the diaspora are the main culprits responsible for certain problems happening in society.

Chapter 3

Methodology

3.1 Data Collection through Algorithmic Autoethnography

To understand how sharding and remediation affects a user in the issue space of immigration, and the controversies present in it, the data was collected primarily from the researcher's personal Instagram account through manual collection. Instagram was chosen as the main platform because of its discursive imagery and hashtags (Rogers 2019). A total of 165 posts were collected over a period of one month from 1st April to 30th April, where the researcher spends one hour browsing through Instagram looking through for content related to immigration of South Asian Diaspora .

According to the Meta Transparency Centre, the Instagram Feed Recommendation System and the Instagram Feed AI system work together to deliver suggested content and connected content respectively. Instead of collecting connected content by following pages and hashtags of posts related to immigration, the posts that were collected solely on the basis of the Instagram Feed Recommendations system which gives suggested content. Once the user starts interacting with a post related to immigration of South Asian Diaspora, the feed recommendation system starts recommending posts through three steps: gathering inventory, leveraging signals and ranking of content. Amongst these three steps the input signals play an influential role in determining the inventory and ranking of content. Amongst these signals, the saving of videos was used as an indicator by the recommendation which indicated if the researcher was interested or not interested in the post. As the number of posts that were saved started to increase, more and more content related to the immigration of the South Asian Diaspora started to appear in the feed (Meta Platforms 2025).

Another factor that influenced in the saving of posts by the researcher was the autoethnographic approach taken to the research. According to Christine Hine, the term autoethnography is “sometimes applied to participants ongoing attempts to articulate and portray their own situation” (Hine 2017, 408). From an autoethnographic perspective, the researcher is considered as a full participant in the situations that they recount. In this case, the researcher is an active member who interacts with the controversies in the issue space of immigration of the South Asian Diaspora by saving the posts. It also focusses on what are the meanings and feelings that these posts evoke on the researcher and other users in the issue space (Hine 2017).

Cunningham and Jones talk about the benefit of autoethnography for its efficacy as a self-reflection tool for understanding the use of technology (Cunningham 2005). Eschler uses this as a base and argues that the reflection on a user's social media data can help in understanding a pattern of how the information flows (Eschler 2016). Parry used autoethnography to study about fandom websites related to football which explored how being part of the website influenced his experience as a fan (Parry 2012). Monaco studied fandom sites based on television shows to explore how at as an autoethnographic participant is able to study how at least one audience member is able to navigate and find meanings in diverse interpretations that other users have about the show (Monaco 2010). Here the researcher from an autoethnographic perspective is trying to navigate and understand the issue space by understanding how different shards based on the same controversy are made and circulated in the issue space. This type of fragmentation (which in this issue space are stories of discrimination, hurt, pain and other experiences experienced by an immigrant diaspora) according to Atay when threaded together has the ability to tell an infused story or how they feel about the subject or topic in the culture or issue space that it is situated in (Atay 2020).

Hine also talks about “how autoethnography can be used in this sense in relation to online interactions, in that the portrayals that participants post online can be viewed as reflexive texts which articulate their readings of their own culture” (Hine 2017, 408). As mentioned above, autoethnography focuses the attention on the feelings that are generated when a user is navigating such interaction in the form of posts and comments. Here the own culture can refer to the issue space that a user experiences in a filter bubble in an echo chamber which differs from user to user. This experience in the context of this thesis is through sharding where the researcher is interacting with multiple shards through saving the posts which is creating a hyporeality. This subjective hyporeality helps in understanding how an algorithmic infrastructure is trying to reaffirm and reassure certain ideas, beliefs and opinions that the controversial shards in the issue space are trying to propagate about the South Asian Diaspora. This in turn can help us understand how users base this infrastructure as a form of personal experience which becomes the basis for generating consent or dissent against the immigration of the diaspora (Hine 2017, 410).

3.2 Methods used for Analysis of Shards

3.2.1 Co-Hashtag Mapping

The first method that was used for the mapping the issue space and its controversies was issue mapping. When combined with co-hashtag maps and labelling of clusters it would show the subcultures or discourses of a particular movement or issue space making Instagram a good option to study publics and counter-publics (Rogers 2024, 197). This visual network analysis using hashtags creates a co-tag network that uses “force-directed layouts” to draw networks in a two-dimensional space (Venturini, Jacomy, and Jensen 2021). Such an exploration according to Venturini et. al. illustrates how to analyse a network by combining three visual operations: “1. the tweaking of a force-directed layout to highlight clusters and structural holes; 2. the sizing of nodes and labels to makes sense of the different regions of the chart; and 3. the colouring of nodes to understand the forces structuring the networks” (Venturini, Jacomy, and Jensen 2021, 7) . This visual representation would give a better understanding of the structure of the network, the controversies that are present as its constituent components of the network and how they are connected with each other. The network is also an apt example showing the importance of hashtag as an affordance of a social media platform like Instagram. But it would be more stimulating to understand how posts that doesn’t have any hashtags would position itself in this network.

3.2.2 Pixplot Visualization and Image Wall

PixPlot is a visualization tool that allows users to explore large image collections in an interactive, graphical way. Developed to handle thousands to millions of images, it employs dimensionality reduction and clustering algorithms to organize images based on their visual similarities. This can make it a useful tool for open-source researchers, digital humanities researchers, archivists, and anyone looking to categorize or find patterns in extensive visual datasets. This visualization is the first step that shows the evidence of sharding in the issue space amongst its controversies.

According to Rogers, “for social or media research, there are basic approaches to studying sets of images with software. When one orders images by formal property and outputs an array of them in the form of an image wall or cluster map, initially it will note one or more dominant images. The dominant image may be studied in terms of a format (such as meme) or as a message (slogan or counter-slogan). It should be noted that the technique also shows the opposite of the dominant. It yields marginal and orphan images” (Rogers 2019). The dominant image refers to the first instance where the video/post was encountered. The marginal and orphan images can be considered as shards and it is these shards tend to form

the story into a complete version which when combined with another affordance of the social media platform, the comments section can result in remediation.

3.2.3 Create scene by scene timelines

Scene by scene timelines according to 4CAT website, creates a timeline for each video as a horizontal collage of sequential frames. Each ‘scene’ in the video is visualized as a single frame. Scenes are detected algorithmically and the timelines for all the videos are stacked vertically and rendered as a single file in the SVG format. By splitting the videos into its constituent frames, the researcher is able to better analyse the similarities between the videos giving further proof of sharding occurs in the issue space (Peters and Hagen, 2022). Also, it also helps to analyse the different formats of the videos, specifically how that are created, which again is another lens that helps understand the preferred format the users would use to push sharding of the controversies in the issue space.

3.2.4 Stack Videos

According to Bainotti and Peeters, Stack Videos offer an audio visual summary that “allows researchers to visualise and analyse the emergence of similarities and differences in memetic components, gestures, audios, video duration, pace and rhythm in a way that wouldn’t be possible if analysing videos one by one” (Bainotti and Peeters 2025, 18) To visualize such image languages or vernaculars, there is the image stack technique, which falls under the larger category of composite images (Colombo, 2018). The same principles are followed by stack videos. In this visualization practice, the order of the images is retained, and each image’s opacity is lowered equally (e.g., with ten images, each is dimmed by 10%). The retention of the order of the layers grants more visibility to the higher ranked images. Ranking here also can be by engagement score. If done in the appropriate manner following the right conditions, this would help in furthering the argument of the significance of sharding in Instagram (Rogers 2019). Moreover, it also highlights the difficulty the users would face in making the right judgements about the controversy as they are inly giving a partial picture/video. The create their own understanding via the comments section of the posts which sets a dangerous precedent that is difficult to control due to permissive potentate nature and profit focussed motives of social media platform and like Instagram and its parent company Meta (Milmo 2021).

3.3 Autonetnographic Analysis of Comments

According to Postill and Pink, studying a social movement involves dealing with a highly disorganized web of connections that acquires significance depending on the place in which these connections are studied (Postill and Pink 2012). This perspective can be applied to the study of an issue space which behaves like a messy network of connections promoting controversies. Both the feed and comments section will change according to the place which influences the algorithm of the platform like Instagram. Therefore, to understand the discourse of the members in the issue space based on sharded data that is collected autoethnographically, a netnographic or more specifically an autonetnographic approach can be taken.

Kozinets developed Netnography to efficiently study such a messy network to understand user motivations and behaviours in this context (Kozinets 2010, Hine 2017, 402). According to Reid and Duffy, “netnography is a way to approach the value of social listening and to provide holistic consumer understanding” (Reid and Duffy 2018, Coombes and Jones 2020, 661). When the researcher combines an autobiographic aspect to the collection of data and combines it with netnography, it results in autonetnography (Coombes and Jones 2020, 662).

Autonetnography according to Kozinets and Kedzior is defined as a “form of observation through searching and lurking and making reflective fieldnotes” (Hine 2017, 409). It is also defined as “an approach to netnography that highlights the role of the netnographer’s own experiences of his or her own online experiences” (Villegas 2018, 243). The term also denotes “an observational phase that focuses on the experience of the researcher as an active agent exploring the territory with a specific focus on how the exhibited information” is consumed and processed online which influences users to come to conclusions like consent or dissent (Hine 2017, 409). As an introspective extension of netnography, it takes the experiential participative elements of the method and adapts it to study “the more internal, micro-psychological adjustments for experiencing virtual worlds” (Kozinets, Scaraboto, and Parmentier 2018, 233).

Already from an autoethnographic perspective, the researcher is able to understand how sharding is creating a hyporeality by promoting certain controversies in the issue space of immigration of South Asian Diaspora. The hyporeality has influenced in “evoking” a layer of opinion in the mind of the users. But this opinion changes when going through the comments. Due to the effect of remediation of these shards through the affordance of

commenting, this remediating idea of the controversies tends to generate consent and dissent against the diaspora from the perspective of other users. By analysing these comments through autonethnography, the researcher is able to understand remediation solely from the perspective of multiple users commenting on the shards of these controversies.

Autonethnography was done qualitatively by going through the top 50 comments manually from the shards present amongst the 165 posts. This gives the opportunity to show how the shard is remediating the main idea that is discussed in the first post or the immediated post and the subsequent hypermediated posts that the researcher encountered while collecting data. Along with the body of the post, the perspective of the users in the form of comments along with the perspective of the researcher would help understand how remediation through sharding is taking a more threatening position when it comes to trusting the information circulating in social media. It would also show how consent/dissent is being manufactured amongst the users with both the issue space and the whole social media ecosystem which spills over into the real world as well at times, through mainstream broadcast media.

In short to understand how sharding together with remediation makes a structure that allows this type of information to flow in Instagram's ecosystem, algorithmic autoethnography was used to analyse the saved posts as shards, which are fragmented and condensed posts curated by the algorithm-based recommendation system. By examining the structural templates of these shards like video format as a form of stimuli to the user, it is helping in documenting how this networked architecture directly captures the researcher's attention and impact their subjective experience which differs from user to user. The comments of these posts will be studied autonethnographically to capture the community driven output and track how tracking how user discourse functions to catalyse or resist remediation within the issue space.

3.4 Researcher Positionality

According to Atay, researchers arrive at a research topic, theoretical framework, or methodological approach for a reason. It most likely speaks to the researcher, where he/she can see themselves in the research topics or methods employed in the study. As bell hooks have written, "I came to theory because I was hurting—the pain within me was so intense that I could not go on living. I came to theory desperate, wanting to comprehend—to grasp what

was happening around and within me. Most importantly, I wanted to make the hurt go away. I saw in theory then a location for healing” (Atay 2020, 268).

India has over the year positioned itself as a premier global supplier for both skilled and unskilled labour. Along with this, the researcher comes from the state of Kerala in India, which has a comprehensive recorded history of both immigration and emigration. It is also interesting to note that the researcher has been exposed to the different cultures through travel and education. As a person currently residing in the Netherlands conforms the identity of the researcher as an immigrant. Hence, the issue space that the researcher is being exposed while living as an immigrant, has the ability to influence certain aspects of his life. The fact that the topic at this particular juncture of history has commanded widespread appeal in both media and academic circles along with the above said qualifications enables the researcher to understand the cultural nuances that helps in understanding how consent and dissent is being generated in social media amongst the users through sharding and remediation in the issue space of immigration. Therefore, studying this process is important to how both information about immigrant and their flow influences both immigrants and natives perspectives about each other.

3.5 Ethical Considerations

Hine writes that according to Kozinets, “commercialisation renders certain parts of the Internet less accessible to ethnographic study because proprietary concerns turn it into a series of password-protected closed worlds where the ethnographer may need to negotiate informed consent, not just with the authors of online texts but with the commercial organisations whom participants may not even realise claim ownership of their words” (Hine, 2017, 411). Hence, the accounts were not chosen by the researcher and was based on the recommendation system of Instagram where posts are public, but consideration was also given both to how the platform is designed to work and user expectations with regard to privacy. The research was careful to use a data minimisation approach by using only what was necessary for the study and mostly has used summaries of comments.

The analysis uses data from only public accounts since to adhere to ethical and legal guidelines for research. Private user data, or any personal identifiable information related to users was not used. The accounts that were chosen as examples were mostly accounts operated under a pseudonym. This is to make sure that such a current sensitive topic is analysed in an open and non-judgmental way. The goal was not to blame or label

communities as problematic but to carefully understand the network and issue space that allow the spread of controversies related to South Asian Diaspora in the issue space of immigration.

Chapter 4

Findings

4.1 Controversies in the Issue Space

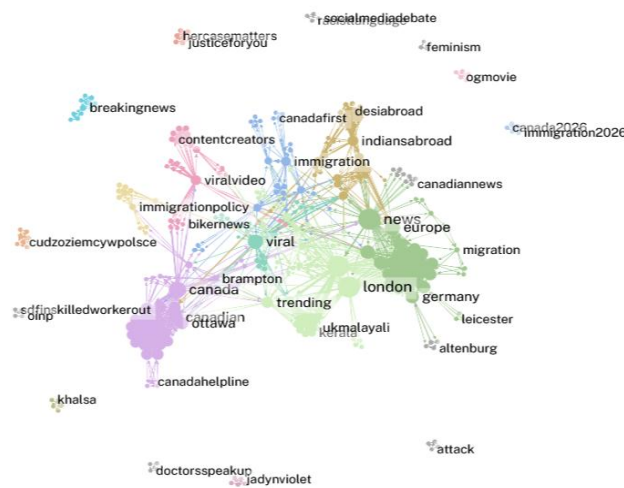


Figure 4.1 Issue Network created based on Instagram Dataset through Retina

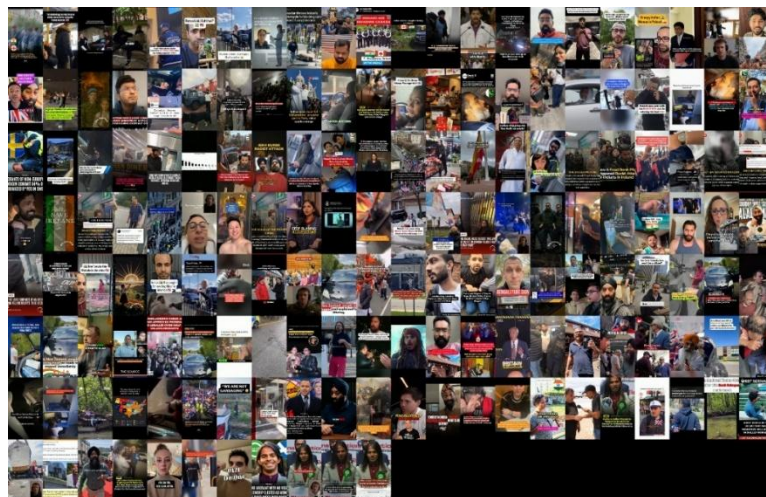


Figure 4.2 Screenshot of Image Wall created via 4CAT

The figure 4.1 above shows the issue space for 165 posts collected from Instagram. To get a better sense of the infrastructure of this issue space, an issue map was created using Retina based on Co-Tag analysis of hashtags and optimized into clusters on the basis of

Louvain community to see the different controversies in the issue space. By using Image Wall and PixPlot Visualization, the researcher was able to find out the details of the corresponding posts related to each of the nodes.

The purple clusters mainly deal with posts related to the South Asian Diaspora in Canada. Within the cluster, a variety of controversies related to racism and violence against the predominant Sikh and other South Asian communities in Canada is shown. It also shows the different places in Canada like Ontario, Toronto, Ottawa and Brampton where these incidents have occurred. Within this cluster there were instances of an old Sikh man being attacked by a masked young immigrant, an Indian being harassed and physically assaulted in McDonalds in Toronto, a coloured immigrant (presumably South Asian) “Ontario” man being made fun of for using his lawnmower in the snow, a road rage incident involving an Indian cyclist and two posts about Sikhs littering in Canada.

The green and light green clusters mainly deal with posts related to the South Asian diaspora in United Kingdom. There is one specific cluster that is focussed mainly on the Malayalee community, which deals with certain controversies that Indian Malayalees have faced. This can be associated with the ethnicity of the researcher which the algorithm accounts for when recommending the posts in the issue space. There are instances of a religious parade of idols by Hindus in Leicester, a South Asian couple asking a person recording the video to leave the premises and a Sikh family that was attacked in Hounslow. Similar to Canada, the cluster also shows different places in UK where the controversies have occurred like Manchester, London, Leicestershire and Birmingham. Another observation in this cluster is the node titled antifascist which is a post that shows a group of right-wing protestors trying to lynch a brown South Asian man. But it is worthy of noting that the post condemns this action and wants to fight against such fascists with an anti-immigrant stance. An interesting aspect to note in this cluster is that there is a significant presence of other European cities within the same cluster like Berlin, Austria, Italy, Stockholm, Barcelona, Vienna and Paris. These nodes represent a single post which was one of the earliest posts saved during the data collection. It shows a supposedly illegal immigrant thrashing a bus and threatening other passengers. This is an example of how a single post has become a significant presence in the cluster because of the affordance of using multiple hashtag.

The blue cluster (despite having no connection with the green cluster) mainly focusses on a specific ongoing controversy related to a Sikh restaurateur, Harman Kapoor. These posts

mainly deal with his arrest by the police and the subsequent reactions posts and follow ups that stems from the first incident. Interestingly in the green cluster, there are two post related to Kapoor where in one, his daughter is reacting to his arrest and another where an influencer is commenting on his action of not serving Halal food. This is an example of how posts are interconnected in a network and how the idea of the same controversy is spreading amongst different clusters.

But at the same time, there is also mentions of controversies related to other topics like the NHS, Reform UK political party and protests. Another major node in this cluster is related to the controversy of grooming where the researcher found a collection of posts wherein members of the South Asian Community where being arrested for trying to groom and engage in sexual relations with underage girls. Interestingly, in the same cluster there are nodes that are used in a post where a vlogger questions a South Asian man in Canada for attending protests. This shows that clusters can be a mixed bag of events and by using the same hashtag, they are being fed into the feed.

The pink cluster mainly focusses on two issues: littering done by the South Asian Diaspora and a road rage incident experience by the member of the community in Canada. The main focal point in this cluster is the node named viralvideo. From this node, it has been connected to other controversies related to UK wildlife law where in one post, a South Asian family is being questioned about a bird that they have taken from the park to their home, which the person assumes is to cook. The pink cluster is also connected to two nodes kebabshop and publicfreakout which points to the controversy where a group of South Asians, presumed to be Indian, had gotten into a fight with the workers in the restaurant for serving beef.

The light blue cluster focusses on two controversies in the immigration issue space of South Asian Diaspora. One controversy is related to famous Russian YouTube prankster Vitaly Zdorovetskiy. In an episode in a series titled Catching Child Predators which was livestreamed in the streaming platform Kick, he had accused a South Asian Man of trying to meet an underage decoy girl and engage in sexual relations. But what makes this controversy different from the controversies discussed in the pink cluster is that the South Asian man named Akash Singhania filed a defamation lawsuit against Vitaly which led to the youtuber apologizing for the incident and admitting that the whole stunt was a prank.

Another controversy discussed in the light blue cluster is a video vlog created by Youtuber Tyler Oliveria, who according to the Anti-Defamation League is known for spreading disinformation and antisemitic content (ADL 2024), where he goes to Portugal to “expose” the invasion of the Sikh Indian community in Portugal. The post is a spliced video from a vlog made by Oliveria that has been posted in a page called thekingdomofnews with the following hashtags: #worldnews and #breakingnews. The post shows Tyler being chased and confronted by Sikhs. Interestingly, the same video is being talked about in the Khaki coloured cluster where a Sikh streamer is completely debasing the claims made by Oliveria in the vlog and appreciating the restraint showed by the Sikhi in the video. Similar to this, a grape-coloured cluster talks about a post which talks about the large-scale propaganda organization against Indians where two people are talking about the unnecessary hate that Indians are receiving online. These clusters show that a strong oppositional voice is also present to signal a counter narrative against the propagated hyporeality that all South Asians are troublemakers in the respective countries.

The light brown cluster discusses Indian members of the South Asian Diaspora which speaks about different controversies like civic sense and crimes against women. One interesting controversy discussed here is the lack of civic sense amongst the South Asian Diaspora where instances of members of the diaspora washing their clothes in rivers or bathing in a children’s swimming pool with soap or publicly celebrating religious customs are discussed. Another controversy that is discussed in this cluster is the crimes against women which is reference to the physical and racial attacks faced by women of the diaspora in Ireland. The node *indiantourists* denotes two posts which discuss an incident of the lack of civic sense where tourists from India when posing with a living statue in Paris chanted ‘Jai Maharashtra’ which sparked outrage and another incident which happened in Russia where Indian men were seen dancing with loud music in the streets.

The orange colour cluster concentrates on two videos of South Asians being interviewed in Poland, where they are asked about the opinion of living in the country.

Grey colour clusters are individual clusters without any connection with the other clusters. Five such clusters discuss very different controversies. The first talks about customer safety, specifically for women while travelling in taxi services like Uber where the driver is from South Asia and is making them feel uncomfortable in the journey. . Two posts in the cluster are posted from the same account discussing two events where a Nepali man is

arrested for “lightly hitting” his wife and a Sri Lankan in Canada arrested for taking videos of women without their permission and harassing them. Another cluster is a post where a South Asian doctor confronts Nigel Farage and tells him that as a doctor, he will respect every immigrant and treat them.

Another cluster which is connected to the green cluster focusses on Q Manivannan, a transgender immigrant who was recently elected to the Scottish Parliament. This is the only post in the grey cluster that has a direct connection with the green cluster in the network. Conversely, there is another cluster which does not have any connection with the purple cluster but discusses the same event of a young immigrant abusing an old Sikh man.

Some posts are missing hashtags and hence are not even present in the issue network created on the basis of co-tag analysis of hashtags. The biggest example is the posts by the account think.about.th1s, bluejeansparty, tyleroliveria. The posts by these accounts do not use any hashtags and are not even present in this issue network. This is an advantage of the autoethnographic method as the researcher is able to manually account for these posts and get a complete understanding of the network that overcomes the limitations of the digital method. This shows that controversies can still spread in the network without using affordances. The same video is posted from different accounts which will show up in the feed of other users. An example of this is the vlog promo of Oliveria. The first post the researcher encountered were shards of the same vlog that was discussed in the previous paragraphs. They had used hashtags, but Oliveria had not and was still able to gain traction.

4.2 Shards of Controversies in the Immigration Issue Space

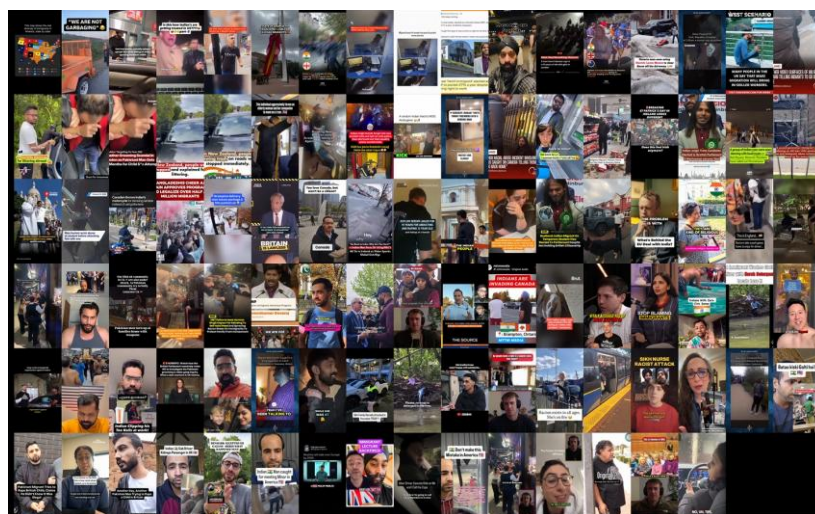


Figure 1.3 Screenshot of Video Wall created via 4CAT

These clusters show the different controversies that are present in the issue space related to the immigration of South Asian Diaspora. The results from Video Wall, Scene by Scene Timeline Stack Video would help us understand pieces of videos of different controversies is circulating as shards in the issue space. The Video Wall gives a small preview of the videos arranged as side by side. Within the wall itself, we are able to get an overview of the controversies in the issue space. It is also the first place where we notice a pattern of sharding in the issue space.

There are three types of videos circulating in the issue space. One video is the original video, that was captured in real time usually from a first-person perspective and is presented as the real footage of the controversy. The next type of videos are commentary videos, wherein youtubers create a new video by playing the shard either in the background or only the video is shown, and the body of the post is where the opinion is written. Through this, they are giving their personal take or comment about the incident that they have seen in their issue space, and this leads to further discussion amongst the followers of the youtuber in the comments section of Instagram. Another type of video is the fragments of podcasts, vlogs and news stories, wherein a shard is created by splicing the important areas of discussion of the podcast/vlog. The vlogs are done mostly through the street interviews (Adams and Wynford Hicks 2001). The news stories on the other hand usually presents the full video with additional information. These videos tend to give an unclear picture to the user seeing the post in the platform and this again leads to further discussions amongst the followers without getting the complete picture. These three video styles tend to be dangerous as the creator and user can easily choose to splice a part of the video which favours their ideology, echo chamber and hyporeality that when posted by different users creates multiple shards.

To get a better sense of the nature of sharding and to better understand the types of shards, the Stack Video and Scene-by-Scene Timeline analysis in 4CAT was used. This will be done by choosing the most repeated controversy categories in the issue space. The analysis of the issue network in the previous section shows that controversies of 1. sexual nature. 2. civic sense, 3. racial abuses and 4. the election of Q Manivannan to the Scottish parliament are the most repeated controversies. In the scene-by-scene analysis and stack video, we can understand that these videos follow a set template. It also shows that there are two types of shards present in the issue space. One shard can be considered as the exact or original copy of the controversy which is being circulated through different accounts. The other type of shards

are the different stories that are circulating related to the same controversy but is posted from a different account.

An important aspect that the researchers need to pay close attention to is the aspect of time or the temporal affordance in social media platforms like Instagram (Kaun and Stiernstedt 2014). If the user observes closely, the person would be able to see when the post was posted and this is only seen in one post amongst 165 posts. A percentage of the users might be under the assumption that the incident being discussed in the video is an incident that has happened recently. Therefore, they tend to react to the incident more vociferously, especially if the post can be associated with their echo chamber or the ideology that they believe in. But from an autoethnographic perspective, if users take a moment to pause and reflect on the incident that they had seen and try to understand the context of the incident and when this incident actually happened, the entire debate of the topic might change completely and could even be extinguished. Moreover, these controversies were collected during a particular time frame. The ever-changing nature of social media and the fact that the feed of every individual is based on a highly individualistic algorithm makes it even more difficult for users to remember if they had seen the same video or differentiate between the controversies. This makes them in risk of encountering misinformation frequently.

Here three videos and their scene-by-scene analysis are selected to understand the template of the shards to help understand how the template is being used to explain the respective selected groups of controversies.

4.2.1 Sexual Assault Cases

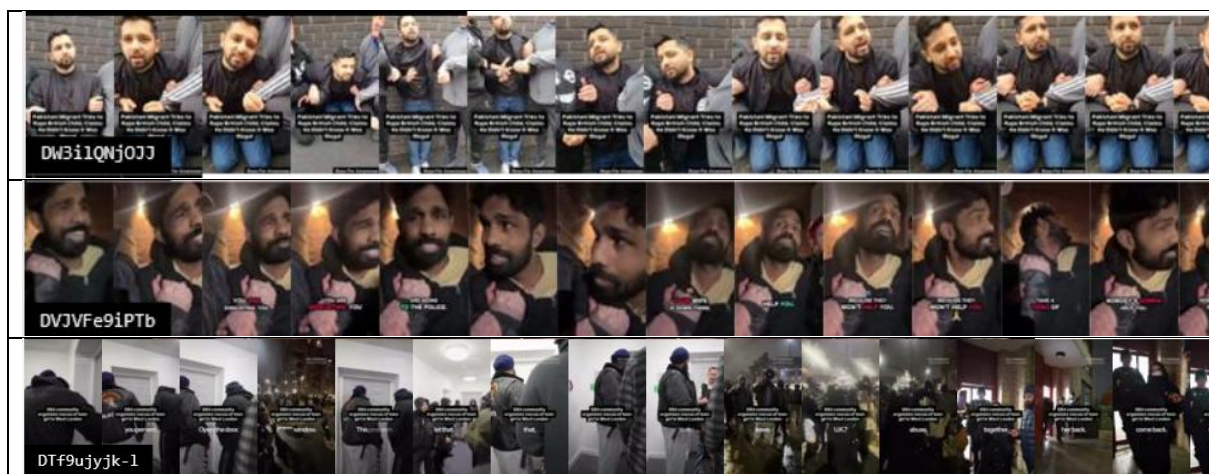


Figure 4.4 Screenshot of Scene-by-Scene Timeline analysis of Sexual Assault Cases

In the case of sexual assault cases, the first two timelines in the table above shows videos that are taken from the first-person perspective. These original videos start in media res or from the middle. They do not show the person engaging in the act of talking with an underage child or being captured by the police. It only shows the accused person being questioned either by the police officers or surrounding civilians/vigilantes (which at times is unclear). They would be apologising for what had happened (which is presumably that they had contacted an underage girl) and would be pleading with the people to not call the police to arrest him and press charges against him.

The first and second timelines are videos in a commentary post/account. An aspect in the first timeline is that the video is not continuous and has been cut at several places which makes it difficult to understand the conversation that happened between the accused and the people who have caught him. It is also interesting to note that in the second timeline in the table, the voice of the people in the video is subtitled to give better clarity of the conversation to the viewer. At the same time, the first timeline does not have any subtitles. While the first timeline mentions through text that a Pakistani migrant has tried to rape a British child, the second timeline discusses a Sikh immigrant being caught for trying to rape an underage female.

The third timeline is a mix of the templates of both the timelines. The video in the timeline was posted in a page called The Juggernaut which identifies itself as a media news company. The timeline gives information about what is happening in the video and the also subtitled to give better clarity to the users. Interestingly, compared to most videos of sexual assault cases found in this issue space, this presents a counternarrative where the Sikh community is trying to rescue a girl from a Muslim grooming gang. Additionally, it should be noted that the post mentions where the video was taken from which the posts of the other two timelines does not mention. Compared to the other two timelines, here the South Asians are not committing a crime, but is trying to stop a crime from happening. This can be seen as a countermedia shard that is showing another aspect that South Asians are not always the culprits. Sometimes they are the victims also.

4.2.2 Civic Sense

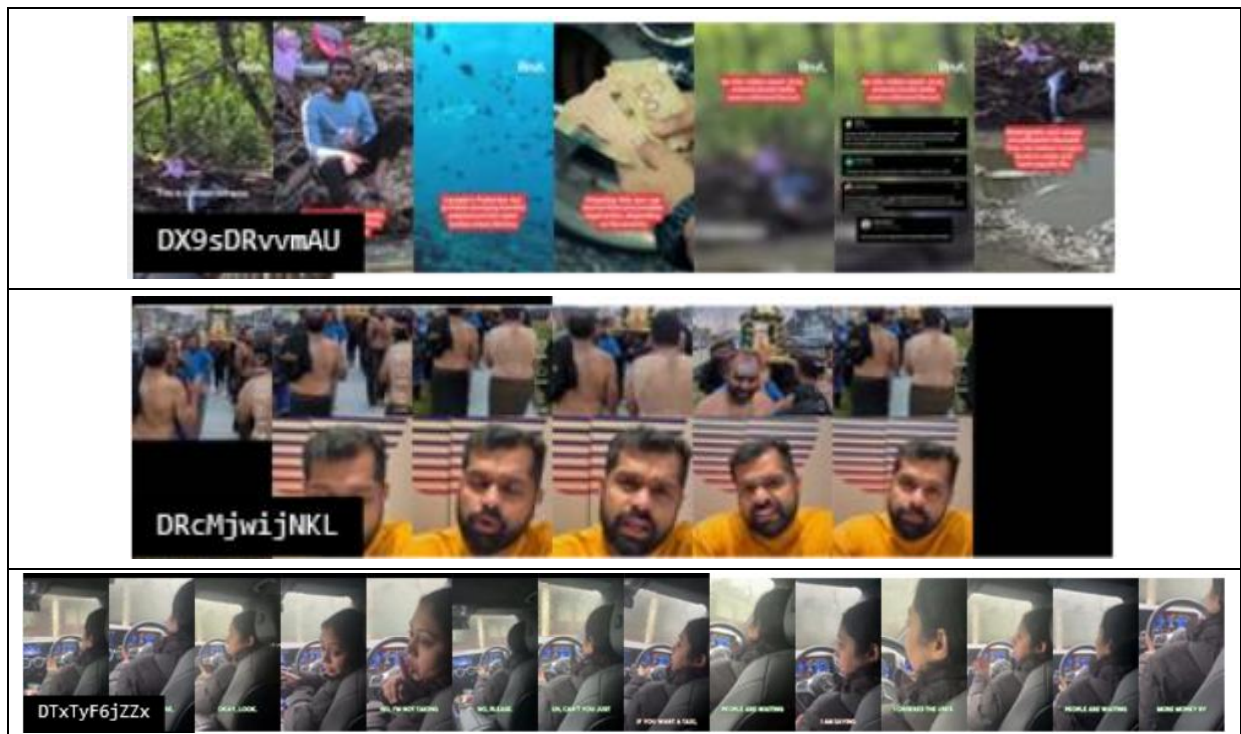


Figure 4.5 Screenshot of Scene-by-Scene Timeline analysis of Civic Sense

In the case of civic sense, the three timelines are based on the three types of videos: news stories, commentary and real footage. The first timeline discusses an incident where a South Asian Man is seen washing his clothes in a river in Canada. Since the video is based on a news story template additional information is added into the video in the form of where it was shot, the rules that the person was violating and the reactions of people to the post in the form of screenshots of their comments. Although the video is cut at several, the cutting here is to give more clarity to the controversy rather than allowing the user to create a conclusion based solely on the video.

The second timeline is a commentary video made by a South Asian commentator. It can be seen in the timeline that the commentator is giving his take on a religious procession being done by a group of devotees. He comments that the actions being done by the devotees is in fact wrong and that at a time where reverse migration is on the rise, this is will only help in promoting dislike and racism against the diaspora as a whole. This is one of the rare instances where a South Asian itself is commenting on a controversy related to the South Asian Diaspora in the issue space of immigration. Instead of giving a biased opinion or supporting the act, the user clearly criticizes these actions and using the template wants to make both South Asian and White people not support such acts where a lack of civic sense results in disturbing other people. The main drawback of this countermedia is that it is in a specific

language, i.e. Malayalam. So, if is this shard is able to move around in the issue space, the language makes it difficult to understand the controversy being discussed.

The third timeline is an original video where a woman from the South Asian Diaspora has trapped a passenger in her taxi and is asking for tips for completing the ride. Subtitles are used to give clarity of the conversation between the driver and the passenger. It is interesting to note that there is a third person in the car shooting the video but does not join the conversation. There is no conclusion to the video and ends abruptly. The video is shot in such a way that tests the patience of the viewer and wants to make it clear to the viewer that this is the attitude of South Asian drivers. This template of the video makes it doubtful that this is a staged video made purposefully by a user to propagate such ideas about the South Asian Diaspora. This is an example of how users are creating fake controversies in the issue space to make more people believe in a specific hyporeality or generate income from the social media platform itself.

4.2.3 Racist Abuses



Figure 4.6 Screenshot of Scene-by-Scene Timeline analysis of Racist Abuses

In the case of racist abuses, all three videos are based on news stories. The first timeline discusses a video of a racial attack being carried out against an old Sikh man by a young

second generation immigrant. The video is a spliced version of three separate scenes. In the first scene, the person is attacking an old Sikh man. In the second scene, a first-person video is being recorded of the attacker asking the old Sikh man what he doing is in his country? The third scene shows the attacker being arrested by the police. Interestingly the same video, with the same template is present in this issue space. But instead of a page that is publishing news stories related to racism, the video of the same template was posted in an individual user's account. The text in the video was also changed. In it, the second-generation immigrant became a crackhead who intended to harm school children and racially abused an elderly man. This is an interesting case where the same video is used, but the text added to the video changes the context of the video itself.

The second timeline is again a spliced video. In the first part, it shows a white woman questioning a South Asian man to leave the country as she believes that such people rape woman. In another video, the same woman tells a South Asian woman to go back to her country, presumably for staring at her. The third part of the video is a collection of comments in support of the actions of the white woman. This template can be taken as an example of how people are influenced by the videos that they are watching in their issue space. The white woman is assuming that all South Asians are problematic which she bases on the information that she is getting from social media which has influenced her hyporeality. This news story is again a form of countermedia to make people understand that racism still exists and that South Asian are victims.

The third timeline is a spliced video of multiple CCTV footages. It is a news about a white man attacking a South Asian immigrant with an axe and injuring his head. The source of the video and the specific details of the controversy including the date of the incident are also added into the video. It ends with the person being arrested by the police. A point to be noted here is that the incident took place in September 2025 and the video was posted on February 2026 on the occasion of the sentencing of the attacker which is also mentioned in the video. This is a rare instance of the time being shown as it makes the users aware that this is a follow up story and not an incident that has happened recently. It is an important aspect that is missing in almost all the timelines of the videos that the researcher saw in the issue space. Most notably, this is also a countermedia which signifies that immigrants are not always the aggressors, but they are the victims as well. But this aspect is not very popular in the issue space.

4.2.4 Election of Q Manivannan



Figure 4.7 Screenshot of Scene-by-Scene Timeline analysis of Election of Q Manivannan

The case of the election of Q Manivannan was able to be present in this issue space as it was a event that was happening concurrently while the data was being collected. Despite it, the researcher encountered six shards based on the same video. The two timelines here show two videos: one is a news story and another is a commentary video. In the first timeline, the news story shows Manivannan introducing themselves and is accompanied with the affordance of music where the song Aarambhame Le from the Telegu movie Jersey is used. The song is usually associated with a sense of accomplishment and pride a person feels after going through many hardships to reach a goal. This is the idea that the video is trying to convey.

But coming to the second timeline it is a commentary video by Michael McCarthy, who has a behaviour of using old videos and reposting them to propagate the idea of the danger that immigration holds and the destruction of the European culture. As soon as McCarthy sees the video, his commentary has been spliced into the video questioning the viewers if this what their forefathers had fought and died for. Timeline two in this situation is a classic example of how bias is easily incorporated by the user. McCarthy through his posts is highlighting the negative side of immigration. The election of an immigrant is turned into a controversy by a user by injecting his prejudice and is successful in convincing his followers of the line he is taking.



Figure 4.8 Screenshot of Video Stack of top four controversies made via 4CAT

The video stack of the four controversies is presented in the table above. An observation worth noting here is that most of the videos is circulating in the issue space of immigration of South Asian Diaspora is highly dissimilar. Only a small percentage of videos use the same controversy repeatedly to propagate ideas about the diaspora. Social media as mentioned previously works on an idea of sameness maximising system of meaning and consumption. But the sharded nature is promoting sameness only in the context of meaning or the crux of the controversy and dissimilarity in the context of consumption. The crux that these controversies are spotlighting is that immigration of the South Asian Diaspora is the cause of many problems in their society and this ‘same’ idea is being shared through a consumption system that is highly sharded. This sharded nature which is highly individualized and dependent on a time frame shows the difficulty that users are facing to come to conclusions about an issue like immigration. It shows that confusion reigns over the issue space.

From an autoethnographic standpoint, amongst these posts, news story template type shards give a more accurate understanding of the controversy that is shared through the post as it was the one that gave the most information in the video itself. Compared to other posts, they have depended less on the other affordances of the platform, specifically the body of the post and give more information to the viewer. But that alone does not help in countering the idea that is spread in the issue space. The other posts and their comments section give every user a chance to inject their bias through commenting making remediation of these same posts possible.

4.3 Remediation through Commentary

The previous section discussed sharding of controversies in the issue space specifically how the template and certain affordances of the platform is helping in promoting a negative idea about the immigration of the South Asian Diaspora. But what happens when the users allow affect and bias to take over and start commenting on the posts that they see. This section will discuss how sharding of the controversies is leading to remediation of the controversy from an autonethnographic perspective and reading the “for you” comments section of the same posts that were discussed in the previous section.

4.3.1 Sexual Assault Cases

The first post that the researcher encounters can be considered as the immediated shard, where the researcher sees the controversy for the first time. An idea of the event is already fed into the mind of the researcher and sometimes the comment section may echo the same feeling. But the subsequent shards can be considered as hypermediated posts where the controversy might be different, but the idea discussed will be given a new twist. This will be completely different from the inference that the researcher makes after seeing the immediated shard. The subsequent comments of these hypermediated shards will be obviously influenced by the posts. Together, a remediation process is happening where the controversy is constantly being remediated at the level of the individual posts and users which depends on the order in which the user will see the shards.

The first instance of remediation to be discussed here is the case of the sexual assault cases where all the users immediately start assuming that the crime of contacting an underage female has been committed, but as shown in the analysis of the template of the shards, there is no proof of this. The users are believing their surface level of analysis and proceeds to comment without any skepticism. The immediation post discussed in the previous section is from an account called stillgray. Most of the comments immediately condemn the actions of the accused. Some comments are commenting on the fact that he is a Muslim, and this is an expected behaviour from the people following the religion. But a majority of the comments are pointing to the fact that he is going to escape justice. Despite being captured and handed over to the police, the commentators believe that the “culprit” will be let go and many believe that the system supports such kinds of behaviour. There are also some comments which discusses that such a person should be punished by castration and then deported immediately to ensure the safety of children and white woman.

The first hypermediated post discussed is from an account called ukpredclips, which mainly focusses on posting such videos where vigilantes capture people who are trying to contact underage girls. The video clearly mentions the accused name as Manpreet which is a Sikh name. But the comments section immediately starts assuming that he is a Muslim and continues to say that the Muslims and the left are partners in crime. An interesting aspect to note here is that some comments try to correct the assumption that the accused is a Sikh by explaining the name. But this does not change the assumption and most of the comments still continue to operate under the prejudice. The post is also now slowly remediating the topic by the increased number of comments supporting castration and deportation of people who are Muslim, Indian or Pakistani and that the actions of such patriots is what that is keeping their streets safe. In short, the comments section is voicing their support for extrajudicial execution and vigilante justice.

The second hypermediated post as mentioned previously remediates the issue to another perspective. The video shows a group of people trying to save a Sikh girl from a Muslim grooming gang. Most of the comments in the comments section are praising the actions of the Sikhs and the initiative that they have taken to stop the crime from being committed by cooperating with the police. While the comments section of the previous video did not notice the Sikh identity and continued with the assumption that the culprit is Muslim, here they are appreciating the Sikhs identity for being model citizens that the people can rely on. But this assumption is again remediated now with the murder of Henry Novak. Now Sikhs are seen as criminals walking around with a knife.

4.3.2 Civic Sense

The immediated post that the researcher discussed while analysing sharding in the case of civic sense was from a news account called Brut. The incident as discussed above shows a South Asian Man washing clothes in a Canadian river. The comments section in turn turns into a heated debate of blame game. Amongst the comments, the blame is placed on the Indians and Pakistanis for the lack of civic sense practised in these communities. But one comments points out the prejudiced assumption that people are making and tries question on what basis they had come to this conclusion. Other comments include discussions about the person being homeless, the person treating the river like Ganga (a polluted river in India) and the need to immediately deport such people due to their lack of civic sense.

The first hypermediated post is from an account called hary_sanker. Most of the comments in this post are in Malayalam. But a majority of them condemns the action of the devotees conducting the procession. They agree with the commentator and also point out that it is such actions that is causing people to have a biased mindset towards Indians and other South Asians. This influences their opinion about them no matter what controversies they end up in. Even if they have not committed a crime, the judgement will be easily passed on to the comments section.

The second hypermediated post is from an account called ukstopscammers. As discussed previously, the video shows a South Asian female taxi driver forcing a passenger to give tips. Although a biased assumption is made about the behaviour of the driver and other comments encourage the ideas of breaking the windows of the car or calling the police or even physically assaulting the driver, some comments directly challenge them. These comments discuss the aspect of the video being a fake and staged video. This can be seen as an example where the remediation is happening in the positive manner where the users are pointing out the shortcomings in the way that the video is shot and making the people aware that such staged videos are circulating in the feed. But this idea is completely buried by the other comments. This positive remediation is overrun by the biased and prejudiced assumptions of the commentators who have already seen other such incidents of the lack of civic sense from the South Asian Diaspora.

4.3.3 Racist Abuses

The first immediated post that the researcher studied in the sharding of controversies related to racial abuse was the post from canadahelpline in which a young man attacks an old Sikh man. The video clearly shows that the young man is racially and physically assaulting the old man. But the comments section is clearly split and remediating into different aspects. One section supports the actions of the young man, another wants to deport all immigrants from the country, another is questioning the responsibility of the children to look after their old parents. The content of the video has started to remediate into a discussion about religion, responsibility and pride for the actions committed by the people in the video.

The first hypermediated post that the researcher saw is a news story video where two incidents of verbal racial abuse done by the same white woman is spliced to show that racism is present in Ireland. The comments section completely remediates into a voicing support for the people specifically Indians who face racism. Such behaviour from the Irish is criticized

vehemently in the other comments which talks the atrocities committed by the Irish as part of the British Raj in India. At the same time, certain comments say that Indians are better choice as immigrants compared to people from countries that have a predominantly Muslim population. The comments also support taking legal action against such people instead of reacting on the spot.

The second hypermediated post is from an account called stvnews, which shows the event of a racial attack by a white man on a South Asian immigrant. The overall discussion in the comments section is vehement support for the attacked immigrant and most of the users wants to throw out the “white scum”. There is also a lack of support for the attacker which was seen in previous posts. One interesting comment in this post talks about how if the attacker was a brown or a South Asian immigrant, then the discussion would immediately shift to the race, culture, community and even the ideologies. This best summarizes the trend of the remediation happening in the issue space especially through the comments section as people with a specific agenda promote or highlight certain aspects that they have seen in other videos. This shows that such countermedia posts are present in the issue space which through the comments section is trying to remediate the whole discussion about the immigration of the South Asian Diaspora to a more positive light compared to the usual negativity that is repeatedly posted as seen in the other posts.

4.3.4 Election of Q Manivannan

The first instance of remediation to be discussed here is the case of the election of Q Manivannan in Scotland. Manivannan’s case is interesting as discussed in the previous section; the shards used the same video in different posts. The first post that came in the feed related to Q Manivannan was in the page titled dailyworldmoments which becomes the immediated shard. The post discussed Manivannan’s achievement in a very positive light, highlighting his identity as a transgender Tamil Indian. The top comments in the post all highlights this aspect, but one user see Manivannan’s gender as a “mental disability.” This story completely changes in the next two posts which are hypermediated shards of the same issue. In one shard which was posted in the page restore_england, instead of praising their victory, they point out that they have been elected while having a temporary visa and explains that their eligibility is one the basis of his identity as an Indian which is considered as part of the Commonwealth. The comments in the post run with this idea and the top comments all criticize their

achievement. It is interesting to note that some comments (which are exactly the same) related to Scottish identity and non-UK citizens ruling UK have been posted repeatedly.

In another post posted in the commentary page [think.about.th1s](#), the comments mainly focus on the takeover of Scotland by the South Asian Diaspora, discussing how they failed William Wallace (a Scottish freedom fighter), how this immigrant is going to be paid to 'rule' them and blames liberal politicians for eliminating the culture of Scotland. The controversy from the perspective of the researcher started as an idea that an immigrant transgender has achieved a major accomplishment. But the subsequent posts clearly changed the narrative. The opinion formed after viewing and reading the comments of the immediated shard has remediated into three different opinions through the hypermediated shards. This lack of consensus is the fertile ground that helps remediation to grow.

In short, the conversation in the comments section is completely influenced by the video that the users are seeing and in most of the instances, the discussion moves away from the incident and remediates into other aspects when the users allow their biases, preconceptions and prejudices to be introduced in the comments. As seen by the study of the comments section, no matter the incident that has happened, the users make conclusions about the incident based on the previous posts that they have seen leading to an affective feedback loop where this prejudiced affect influences their opinions about the controversy involving a certain diapsora. And this order will differ from user to user. This combined with the bias that propagates both controversies and the remediation of the ideas associated with it makes it a growing risk for the people to get a true understanding of the events that they are seeing through social media. The platforms controlling these social media will profit from such modes of consumption, but it governments and the people, as seen in the case of Henry Novak, is at risk if these posts are not controlled and allowed to overflow into real world which causes real consequences in society like the ones discussed in the comments. If social media was used as a tool in Arab spring for the liberation of the countries, it is important to remember that it was also used for promoting violence against the Rohingyas in Myanmar (Fink 2018) (Wolfsfeld, Segev, and Sheaffer 2013). Therefore, the remediated meanings that users generate through the consumption of shards in an issue space like immigration generates meanings and conclusions that has the potential to generate consent and dissent against a diaspora like the South Asians.

Chapter 5

Conclusion

The medium through which information is consumed today and the meaning that is derived from it is under a state of flux. As understood from the discussion above, anyone with an access to a phone and an account in a social media like Instagram can create a post based on a previously posted video content. This has clearly influenced how information and news is being consumed through social media especially amongst young users (Vázquez-Herrero, Negreira-Rey, and Sixto-García 2022). The ‘meaning’ produced through this process according to Stine Lomborg, “highlights the generative process by which users negotiate the communicative potentials and constraints of a text or a medium vis-a-vis the individuals’ preexisting mental models, expectations, and intentions in context” (Lomborg 2015). It shows that people already have a preexisting base of knowledge and prejudice that affects the way that they consume information.

A post of controversy in an issue space like immigration today is part of a media story which acts like an assemblage of other media stories (Toivanen, Nelimarkka, and Valaskivi 2021, 2131). Here, an active choice is made by the users (both creators and audience) and the algorithm where, reframing constantly occurs through sharding of these stories. This along with the preexisting knowledge (of stories in the form of posts) of the users influences the remediation in the comments which tend to distort the original content or point discussed in the post. Two layers of meaning generated through sharding and remediation is the main factor that influences the generation of consent and dissent against a diaspora like the South Asians in an issue space like immigration.

It was interesting to note that in some posts they had used the same or an edited version of the following disclaimer to justify the shard they had made by using a source video:

“Fair Use Disclaimer This video is for informational and news reporting purposes, falling under the Fair Use Doctrine (17 U.S.C. §107). It provides original commentary, critique, and a thoughtful revision, contributing added value beyond the original sources.”

But from the study done in this thesis, instead of a thoughtful revision, the post is revised to propagate biases, fears and prejudices of the users. Instead of adding value, it is creating a minefield or a ticking time bomb which may or may not have been intended by the

‘influencer’. This is one of the reasons why recently the government in Singapore blocked access to 14 online posts that targeted Indian communities in Singapore (Devaraj 2026) (Aqil Hamzah 2026).

Allowing information to be in such a state of sharded free flow can cause serious consequences which was what that prompted the Singapore government to act swiftly. This helped in the accurate risk management that stopped the Overton Window from shifting and expanding (Astor 2019). At a time when Instagram’s parent company Meta is taking measures to reduce fact checking by ending their third-party fact checking program (Hermans, Waeterloos, and Opgenhaffen 2025), the sharding and remediation in an issue space is expected to increase even more which allows certain users to set the agenda through lobbyism without any limitations.

In short, this study tries to show that consensus surrounding the controversies related to the immigration of South Asian diaspora is no longer formed only through person-to-person discussions or traditional news broadcast media. Instead, it is continuously shattered into multiple digital shards by a highly personalised recommendation algorithm that forces users to piece together, negotiate, and remediate by interacting through affordances, specifically the messy affordance of the comment section. This study can be further expanded by gaining access to the Instagram API data from the parent company Meta. This data will allow to better understand the source of the original immediated post and better see how the post travelled from shard to shard. This will help in better understanding the route the shards can take. It would also help in explaining how certain accounts act as lobbyists that will help in narrowing down consequences by educating and ensuring that proactive action is taken from the sides of the user, the platform and the government.

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Instrumentography

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